The next day we got tangible evidence we were creating the coalition we needed. Sixty-three Democrats defied Tip and voted along with every Republican in the House for the Gramm-Latta budget resolution, the first of a series of congressional actions that slashed billions of dollars in federal spending in 1981. “We never anticipated such a landslide,” I wrote in my diary. “We felt we were going to win due to the conservative bloc of Dems, but expected Republican defections so that we might win by one or two votes. It’s been a long time since Republicans had a victory like this.”

Joining the Republicans was a group of Democrats who, like Representative Phil Gramm of Texas, called themselves the “boll weevils” and shared our philosophy that government was spending too much of the national wealth and wanted to cut it back. Without their help, we would have never passed the economic recovery program.

As sweet as this initial victory was, we had a long way to go on the two fronts of cutting spending and cutting taxes. I realized I would have to compromise and settle for less than the full thirty-percent, three-year cut I wanted, but got some plums I hadn’t expected: In late May, a group of Democrats announced a counterproposal to our tax plan that rejected the thirty-percent-over-three-years cut, but accepted a smaller cut in personal income tax rates while proposing a reduction in the top rate on unearned income from seventy percent to fifty percent. I’d wanted that in the first place, but figured the Democrats would attack us for pandering to the rich, so we hadn’t asked for it in our package. To get on the people’s new antitax bandwagon, some Democrats also called for indexing income tax rates, so that rates would decline each year in step with inflation and end “bracket creep.” That was something else I wanted but doubted we could get.